Renke, etc.), in Pune (by Dakshinayan), in Mumbai (by Medha Patkar, Feroze Mithiborwala, Irfan Engineer, Ulka Mahajan, Pratibha Shinde, etc.), in Nanded (by D.P. Sawant, etc.), for which we had to travel across the state. It was admittedly very tiring, but we ended up connecting and reconnecting with a galaxy of civil society organizations and movements. It was very illuminating to learn the nuances of different issues and the dynamics of each district.

There is a widely held perception that politicians (both elected and organizational) are competitively cut-throat and selfish. And conversely, civil society keeps selfish interests aside for the larger good. This was something even I secretly believed in, though I have been a political activist for almost two decades. The preparatory work for the Yatra burst this perception. Even though the party was competitive (like it always has been), ultimately everyone came together to work towards the shared goal. And this wasn't something that had to be enforced from above. It was an organic self-realization, and this was very evident in the manner in which every leader (and their respective factions) worked collaboratively. This is not to suggest that they still didn't want to do things their own way and have their say. They did. But they cooperated with each other. Needless to say, much more could have been done (and certainly more efficiently) if there had been better communication between factions. If only they had spoken regularly with each other (rather than during formal meetings), they would have seen that they were all equally committed to their shared goals and values. Their differences were only in the way they wanted to do things, but their end goals were the same. But by and large, things within the Congress ran smoothly.

But in stark contrast, the competitiveness within civil society was cut-throat. People would say one thing and do the exact opposite. Many senior activists were unwilling to share credit or work together, and held on to old antipathies. There were some notable exceptions, but by and large they were unwilling to band together to lead a unified effort in their stated support for the Yatra. That is one of the reasons why there were multiple meetings and efforts. This was compounded by the fact that a couple of